Payday Spire

Development Budget

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Zoud GameLab 2026
"Make FinLit Fun"

Scope: take the jam prototype to a commercial release in 12 months, following the official milestone schedule (Design Document, Playable Alpha, Playtest Beta, Commercial Launch). Exchange rate: 1 USD = 3.6725 AED. AED values are rounded.

#	Item	Basis	USD	AED
1	Lead developer and designer (solo, Seoul)	12 months x USD 2,500 (about 80 h per month at USD 31)	30,000	110,175
2	2D artist and UI designer (remote contract)	260 h x USD 30: card faces for about 25 card kinds, about 20 enemy illustrations, the battle screen and icons	7,800	28,646
3	Music and sound (fixed fee)	final mix of the code-made music loop and about 25 SFX, plus 2 battle loops	1,300	4,774
4	Arabic localization and native review	about 9,000 words x USD 0.12, plus RTL fit pass and a review round by a Gulf native speaker	1,800	6,610
5	Islamic finance (Shariah) content review	20 h x USD 125, UAE-based scholar or firm, written sign-off on rules and wording (zakat, nisab, qard hasan, profit sharing)	2,500	9,181
6	Financial-literacy educator	40 h x USD 60, learning goals, lesson plan, pre/post check	2,500	9,181
7	Accessibility audit	WCAG 2.2 AA manual audit of about 10 screens plus re-check	2,500	9,181
8	QA, device and balance testing	130 h x USD 20, low-end Android, iOS Safari, school laptops, and balance runs for each scenario pack's deck and enemies	2,600	9,549
9	Playtests (two rounds, at least 35 independent testers)	60 vouchers x USD 25, recruiting, session tools; most sessions in UAE classes and universities	2,500	9,181
10	Hosting, domain, privacy-safe analytics, tools	12 months	1,200	4,407
11	Store accounts and packaging	Google Play, Apple, Steam app fee, PWA/Capacitor packaging	600	2,204
12	Launch plan and outreach	Trailer cut from gameplay capture, school and partner demo kit, 60-day launch plan	2,900	10,650
13	Legal	Privacy policy for school use, contractor agreements, winner-agreement review	2,500	9,181
14	Payment and transfer costs	Bank/Wise/FX deductions on award, about 1.2%	700	2,571
15	UAE local work	One pilot visit to UAE schools and partners (flight, 5 nights, local travel: USD 1,700) plus a UAE local coordinator (20 h x USD 40: USD 800)	2,500	9,181
	Subtotal		**63,900**	**234,673**
16	Contingency	about 3.5% of subtotal	2,210	8,116
	Total		**66,110**	**242,789**

What a deck-builder changes against a standard budget for this scope (same total): more art (line 2: every card and enemy needs a face; +USD 1,800) and more balance testing (line 8: each scenario pack is a new deck and enemy set that has to be run through the balance check; +USD 600). Paid for by a smaller sound line (line 3: the sound effects and the music loop are already made in code; -USD 500), a trailer cut from gameplay capture (line 12; -USD 600) and a smaller contingency (line 16; -USD 1,300).

Milestones and payments (1st place case; 2nd and 3rd place receive USD 5,000 in the first payment and the same 10/30/30/30 split of the rest)

Payment	Month	Deliverable	USD	AED
P1	Submission	Game, budget and concept document received	7,500	27,544
P2	2	Game Design Document approved	5,861	21,525
P3	6	Playable Alpha: 3 scenario packs (deck and enemy sets), teacher mode, Arabic and Shariah review applied, new card and enemy art	17,583	64,574
P4	9	Playtest Beta: 35+ independent testers in 2 rounds, findings report, accessibility audit passed	17,583	64,574
P5	12	Commercial Launch: stable V1 on at least one storefront, 60-day launch plan	17,583	64,574

Scaled scope if the award is lower than requested

Award tier	Total budget USD	AED	Scope kept
Up to 70,000	66,110	242,789	Full plan above
Up to 30,000	29,820	109,514	1 scenario pack, new card faces for the starter deck and the bosses, EN/AR, Shariah and educator review, web/PWA and one storefront, 35-tester beta
Up to 15,000	15,000	55,088	Polish the current 12-month year, Arabic UI, Shariah review, 35-tester beta, one storefront

Spending by phase (total spending never runs ahead of total payments received)

Phase	Months	Planned spending	Total spent by end of phase	Total received by end of phase	Main items
P2	1-2	13,250	13,250	13,361	Developer 5,000, educator 2,500, legal 2,500, Arabic native review 1,800, Shariah review 1,250, hosting 200
P3	3-6	17,650	30,900	30,944	Developer 8,700, art 5,200, sound 1,300, Shariah review 1,250, QA 800, hosting 400

Phase	Months	Planned spending	Total spent by end of phase	Total received by end of phase	Main items
P4	7-9	17,600	48,500	48,527	Developer 5,300, art 2,600, accessibility 2,500, QA and balance 1,800, playtests 2,500, UAE local work 2,500, hosting 400
P5	10-12	17,610	66,110	66,110	Developer 11,000, store 600, launch 2,900, hosting 200, payment costs 700, contingency 2,210

Part of the developer fee for months 3 to 9 (USD 3,500) is paid in P5, so spending stays inside the payments received.

Developer time: the lead developer works about 80 hours a month on Payday Spire for all 12 months (line 1). Progress is shared in a monthly progress report and checked through the milestone deliverables.

Assumptions: contractor rates are market ranges (remote 2D artist USD 30/h, QA USD 20/h, Arabic localization USD 0.12 per word, WCAG audit USD 2,500). Shariah review, educator, sound and UAE travel costs are estimates to be confirmed by written quotes. Payment costs are included because award amounts are inclusive of bank and conversion costs.